

Sony WH-CH720N

Making top-tier ANC accessible

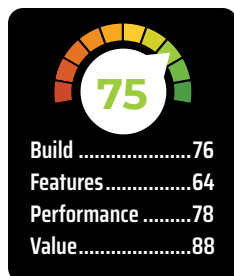
It's been a hot minute since I've had the chance to review a pair of headphones from Sony's WH-CH lineup. Sony recently launched the Sony WH-CH720N noise-cancelling headphones and it looks undeniably promising on paper. However, does it deliver the promise of flagship-grade ANC on a budget mixed with balanced sound? Let's find out:

BUILD, DESIGN, AND COMFORT

The Sony WH-CH720N definitely borrows some design cues from its more expensive cousin – the WH-1000XM5. The coloured accents on the Mark 5s are missing. The plastic portion of the cups is a bit bulkier, more in line with the older Sony WH-1000XM4, but overall, this is a good-looking pair of mid-range headphones. The leatherette headband is soft and cushiony. However, it feels slightly less padded compared to the 1000XM5. The same is true for the memory foam earcups – a bit lighter on the padding, but comfortable, nonetheless. You can easily wear these cans for hours on end without discomfort, and there's no hotspot created on top of the head as well. The materials used definitely feel cheap. However, you'll hardly hear any creaks when you pull the earcups apart, so major props to Sony for that.

FEATURES

The Sony WH-CH720N is sufficiently feature-laden for its price point. You've got Active Noise Cancellation with an integrated V1 processor, Transparency Mode, Sony Headphones Connect app support, and Multi-Connect. The Sony Headphones Connect app is brimming with features and customisation options. This time was no different. You've got a customisable 5-band EQ in the app



that you can modify as per your preferences. There's also 360 Reality Audio, but the apps that support this Spatial Audio-like feature are extremely limited in India. The app also allows you to toggle DSEE (Digital Sound Enhancement Engine). Sony has given a few features the skip, though. On-ear detection, IP rating, and fast charging are missing, which is slightly disappointing. I really missed fast charging and feel that it is a basic enough feature which should be included at almost every price point.

PERFORMANCE

The Sony WH-CH720N has a pleasant sonic signature with a bit of bass bias to give your music the extra oomph. Sadly, the headphones only support SBC and AAC audio codecs. Despite that, the Sony WH-CH720N packs a punch for its price. The sonic fidelity is quite impressive – especially when you turn DSEE on. In the frequency response curve, the WH-CH720N has slightly more boosted bass than the Sony WH-1000XM5 in the low bass region from 30 Hz to 80 Hz. The result is a clean sound that has character while still being pretty balanced as a whole. Our only complaint is that the drop-off in the highs is a bit harsh and can be slightly jarring in some tracks – but that is me nitpicking. For the price, the sound quality is impressive. When I first

put on these cans and turned on ANC, I was pleasantly surprised by how effective it was. Very close to flagship level at just ₹10K. It only has difficulty suppressing human voices, which is understandable at this price. The Ambient Mode is also pretty good and sounds natural as well – works as advertised. Finally, the headphones come with beamforming microphones, and the call quality is quite decent. My voice was clear on phone calls but the microphones did pick up a lot of ambient noise. The wireless connection is quite strong, courtesy of Bluetooth v5.2. The pairing process is a breeze, and subsequent connections with paired devices are almost instantaneous.

BATTERY LIFE

The battery life of the Sony WH-CH720N isn't much of an upgrade over its predecessor. In our battery test, I recorded 33 hours and 21 minutes of playback time with ANC turned on and the volume levels set to 60 per cent, quite close to Sony's claim. However, as far as I could tell in my tests, the cans do not come with fast charging, which is a big disappointment. The cans take a laborious 3.5 hours to charge to full from an empty battery, which is far too long in 2023.

VERDICT

The Sony WH-CH720N ticks plenty of boxes. Our only complaints are the battery life and the lack of high-quality codecs. The battery life, while decent, is on the lower end of the standard in 2023 and there is no real improvement over its predecessor in this area. All that said, the Sony WH-CH720N is definitely going to be one of our foremost recommendations to those looking for a solid noise-cancelling pair of headphones in and around the ₹10K.

–Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

Headphone type: Closed-back, Over-ear | Driver size: 30 mm dynamic driver | Impedance: 325 ohms (when turned on) | Sensitivity: 108 dB / mW | Weight: 192 g | Bluetooth: v5.2 | Codecs: SBC, AAC | Passive operation: Yes, 1.2 m cable

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